

Plush : Know Your Water

What's in your city's water, and what to do about it.

BEFORE YOU START

Your water already has a report card. Let's read it.

Every city water system in the U.S. publishes a report about its water, once a year. It's public, it's free, and almost nobody reads it.

This guide shows you where to find yours, and how to read it in about 30 seconds. No scare tactics, no lab coat. Just your city's own numbers, and what they mean.

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Thanks for being here.

Yasser

CEO, Plush

01

Your water has a report card

It's called a Consumer Confidence Report, or CCR. Some cities call it a Water Quality Report. Same thing.

Who has to publish it

Every community water system in the U.S. That's any system serving at least 25 people, or 15 homes, all year. If you pay a water bill to a city or a utility, you're covered. The rule comes from the Safe Drinking Water Act.

When

Every year, by July 1. It covers the year before. So the report you'll find this year shows last year's tests.

What's in it

Where your water comes from

A river, a lake, a reservoir, or groundwater from wells.

How it's treated

The steps your utility uses before the water reaches your pipes.

What was detected

Every regulated substance found in testing, with the level measured.

Any violations

Whether a legal limit was exceeded, and what the utility did about it.

> **On a private well?** Wells aren't covered by these reports. You'd have to test the water yourself, with a certified lab.

The report talks about drinking water. Your shower runs on the same water, from the same pipes.

02

Find yours in 3 minutes

Four ways. The first one works most of the time.

1. **Search for it**
   Type *"[your city] water quality report"* or *"[your city] consumer confidence report"*. Most utilities post it as a PDF on their website.

2. **Look at your water bill**
   The utility's name is on it. Many bills also print the link to the report, often near the bottom.

3. **Use the EPA's search**
   Go to **epa.gov/ccr** and use "Find your local CCR". Pick your state, then your water system.

4. **Call and ask**
   Call the number on your water bill and ask for the "Consumer Confidence Report". They're required to make it available to you.

> **Renting?** Your landlord may pay the water bill, but the report still covers your water. Search by your city or your utility's name.

Tip. Big cities sometimes have several water systems. If your report lists more than one, look for the area or ZIP code that matches your home.

03

Read it in 30 seconds

Skip the intro pages. Go straight to the big table. It usually looks like this.

SUBSTANCE	UNIT	MCL	YOUR LEVEL	RANGE	VIOLATION	LIKELY SOURCE
Chlorine	ppm	MRDL 4	**1.2**	0.6 – 2.0	**No**	Water additive used to control microbes
Nitrate	ppm	10	**1.4**	ND – 2.8	**No**	Runoff from fertilizer use
Total trihalomethanes	ppb	80	**34**	18 – 51	**No**	By-product of drinking water disinfection

Example only. Numbers are made up to show the layout. Your city's table will have its own substances and numbers.

Look at three things, in this order

1. **The Violation column**
   "No" all the way down means every result was within the legal limits that year.

2. **Your level next to the MCL**
   The MCL is the legal limit. Your city's number should sit below it. The gap tells you how far below.

3. **The disinfectant line**
   It says "chlorine" or "chloramine". Write down which one. Chapter 4 explains why.

Detected doesn't mean unsafe. Reports list everything that was found, even at levels far below the limits. The report gives you the numbers. What you do with them is up to you.

03 · READ IT IN 30 SECONDS

The words, decoded

Every report uses the same short words. Here they are.

MCL	**Maximum Contaminant Level.** The highest level of a substance allowed in drinking water. It's the legal limit.
MCLG	**Maximum Contaminant Level Goal.** A goal set by the EPA, often lower than the MCL. It's a target, not a limit.
MRDL	**Maximum Residual Disinfectant Level.** The limit for disinfectants like chlorine and chloramine: 4 ppm.
AL	**Action Level.** Used for lead and copper. If too many homes test above it, the utility has to take extra steps.
90th %ile	For lead and copper: 90% of the homes tested were at or below this number.
TTHM, HAA5	By-products that form when disinfectants meet natural material in water. Reports list them with their own limits.
ND	**Not detected.** Testing didn't find it.
NA	**Not applicable.**

Units

UNIT	MEANS	SAME AS
ppm	parts per million	mg/L (milligrams per liter)
ppb	parts per billion	µg/L (micrograms per liter)

1 ppm = 1,000 ppb. Always compare numbers in the same unit.

04

Chlorine or chloramine?

Your utility adds a disinfectant to keep the water clean all the way through the pipes to your tap. That's required, and it's a good thing.

Chlorine

The classic. It's the reason some showers smell a little like a swimming pool.

Chloramine

Chlorine combined with a small amount of ammonia. It lasts longer in big pipe networks, so many large cities use it.

More than one in five Americans gets water treated with chloramine, according to the EPA.

How to know which one you have

Find the disinfectant line in your report. Look for **chlorine**, **free chlorine**, **total chlorine**, **chloramine**, **chloramines** or **monochloramine**. Still not sure? Your utility will tell you in one phone call.

Why it's worth knowing

Filters are built for specific jobs. Different filter materials handle different things, at different speeds. Knowing which disinfectant your city uses helps you judge any filter honestly, including ours.

A good question to ask any filter brand: "What is your cartridge designed to reduce, and was it tested?" A clear brand will give you a clear answer.

05

Hard water, in numbers

Hard water is water with a lot of dissolved calcium and magnesium. It's not a safety issue. It's what leaves white spots on your shower door.

Your report may list hardness in **mg/L** (sometimes written "as $CaCO_3$") or in **grains per gallon (gpg)**. To convert: **1 gpg = 17.1 mg/L**.

Soft	Moderately hard	Hard	Very hard
0 – 60 mg/L	61 – 120 mg/L	121 – 180 mg/L	over 180 mg/L
0 – 3.5 gpg	3.6 – 7 gpg	7.1 – 10.5 gpg	over 10.5 gpg

Scale used by the U.S. Geological Survey.

What you'll notice

White spots on glass and faucets. A crust on the shower head. Soap that doesn't lather much.

> **Straight talk.** Plush is not a water softener. No shower filter removes hardness. If very hard water and white spots are your main problem, a water softener is the right tool. We'd rather tell you now.

Quick fix for spots. Wipe the glass with equal parts white vinegar and water, then rinse. A squeegee after each shower keeps them from coming back.

06

Install Plush in 2 minutes

No tools. No plumber. Plush fits the standard U.S. ½-inch shower arm.

1. **Turn the water off.**
2. **Unscrew your old shower head by hand, counter-clockwise.**
   If it won't budge, grip it with a dry dish towel.
3. **Check the rubber washer inside the Plush head.**
   It's already in there. Leave it.
4. **Screw Plush on by hand, clockwise, until it stops.**
   Hand-tight is tight enough. No wrench, no tape.
5. **Run the water for 30 seconds before your first shower.**
   A new filter releases a little carbon dust. It's normal, and it only happens once.

> **Moving out?** Screw your old shower head back on and take Plush with you. Nothing to repair, nothing to leave behind.

Something's off? Email **info.tryplush@gmail.com**. A real person reads every message.

07

Day 30: look at your cartridge

On day 30, unscrew the cartridge and hold it next to a new one. Or next to the photo below.



We didn't make it brown. Your water did.

What you see is what stayed in the cartridge instead of coming out of your shower head.

Every city's water is different, so every cartridge looks different. Some turn tan, some turn rust, some barely change. A color isn't a verdict on your water. It just shows you the filter at work.

When to change it

About every 3 months, or sooner if the flow feels weaker. Unscrew the old one, screw in the new one. No tools.

Never run out. Get a new cartridge every 3 months with Subscribe & save, and cancel anytime: **myplush.us/products/plush-replacement-cartridge**

Took a day-30 photo? Send it to **info.tryplush@gmail.com**. We'd love to see what you saw.

08

Your water card

Fill it in with your report open. Print it, or screenshot it and keep it on your phone.

City

Water utility

Report year

Water source ☐ River or lake ☐ Groundwater ☐ Both

Disinfectant ☐ Chlorine ☐ Chloramine ☐ Not sure

Hardness _____ mg/L or _____ gpg

Hardness level ☐ Soft ☐ Moderate ☐ Hard ☐ Very hard

Any violations? ☐ None ☐ Yes, for:

Plush installed on

Day 30 check

Next cartridge

plush

City water in.
Plush water out.

Questions about your report, your shower or your order? Email **info.tryplush@gmail.com**. A real person reads every message, and we reply within 2 business days.

Sources. U.S. Environmental Protection Agency: Consumer Confidence Reports (epa.gov/ccr) and chloramines in drinking water. U.S. Geological Survey: hardness of water.

This guide is for general information only and is not medical advice. Plush is not a medical device and is not intended to diagnose, treat, cure or prevent any condition. Plush is not a water softener. Filter capabilities refer to what the filter is designed to reduce, not to the guaranteed presence of those substances in your water. Individual results vary.

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